



## What is a lead?

A lead is an opening paragraph that gives the audience the most important information of the news story in a concise and clear manner, while still maintaining the readers' interest. If a reader does not read beyond your first paragraph, they should still have an idea of what your article is about and the most important information from that article.

## Techniques for effective leads

- Identify the most newsworthy aspect of the story by considering timeliness, proximity, prominence, impact, and novelty, focusing on the element that will most likely capture the reader's attention
- Choose the appropriate lead type as a summary lead for breaking news or hard news stories. Consider an anecdotal lead for human-interest stories or to provide a personal perspective. Employ a descriptive lead for feature stories or to set a scene.
- **Focus on the 5Ws and H**  
Before writing a lead, consider which part of the story—who, what, when, where, why, and how—is most crucial. You should highlight those points in your lead.
- **Be specific and clear**  
Though most leads need you to summarise content, you must attempt to be as precise as possible. Your lead will not be useful or intriguing if it is too big.
- **Concision**  
Readers would like to discover why the narrative is important to them, and they won't wait long to find out. Leads are usually one or two sentences long. They are typically between 25 and 30 words in length and should never exceed 40.
- **Use Active Voice**  
Powerful verbs will make your lead more vibrant and engaging. Passive sentences, on the other hand, might seem boring and leave out vital information, such as who or what prompted the action.

## Components of lead

Here are the key components of a news lead:

### 1. Who

- Identifies the subject(s) of the story. This can be a person, group, organization, or even an object or event, depending on the news angle. The "who" is central because it informs the audience about the main players involved.

### 2. What



- Describes the main action or event. This tells the audience what has happened or what is currently happening. It's crucial because it provides the core newsworthy aspect.

### 3. When

- Specifies the time when the event or action occurred. Readers often want to know if it's recent, ongoing, or something scheduled for the future.

### 4. Where

- Indicates the location where the event took place or is expected to happen. For local and national stories, the location adds relevance to the reader.

### 5. Why

- Explains the reason or motivation behind the event. This can delve into causes, goals, or justifications. Understanding the "why" helps readers grasp the significance or implications of the event.

### 6. How

- Details the process or method of how the event unfolded or will unfold. This can cover logistics, strategies, or approaches taken by those involved.

## Types Of Leads

News leads serve as the opening of a news article and set the tone for the story. Here are the main types:

### Summary Lead

Provides the most important information upfront, often answering who, what, when, where, why, and how. It's concise and straightforward.

*Example: "The CM of Punjab announced a new policy to reduce traffic congestion by imposing peak-hour tolls, starting in January 2025."*

### Delayed Lead

Withholds key details initially to build interest. It may start with a narrative or anecdote before revealing the main facts.



## **Anecdotal Lead**

Begins with a story or personal experience, drawing readers in emotionally before presenting the broader news context.

*Example: "'I lost everything,' said John Smith, standing in front of the charred remains of his apartment. Smith is one of the 20 residents left homeless by a massive fire that tore through the downtown apartment complex last night"*

## **Question Lead**

Opens with a question to engage readers' curiosity. However, it's less common in professional journalism.

*Example: "Will Pakistan's new renewable energy policy help solve the country's persistent power shortages?"*

## **Quotation Lead**

Starts with a compelling quote that encapsulates the essence of the story, providing insight or emotion right away.

*For Example : "'We are committed to eradicating polio from every corner of the country,' said Prime Minister Anwaar-ul-Haq Kakar, as the government launched a nationwide vaccination campaign."*

## **Descriptive Lead**

Uses vivid imagery or detail to create a scene, helping readers visualize the story.

For Example :

*"As the morning sun rose over the bustling streets of Lahore, shopkeepers hurriedly opened their shutters, while the aroma of freshly baked naan filled the air. Amid the daily routine, a wave of excitement spread as residents gathered to witness the inauguration of the city's first eco-friendly public transport system."*

This lead paints a vivid picture of the scene, drawing readers in with sensory details and setting the stage for the main story.

## **Statistical Lead**

Begins with a surprising statistic or fact that highlights the significance of the news, grabbing attention with hard data.

For Example :



*"Nearly 40% of Pakistan's population lacks access to clean drinking water, according to the latest report by the World Health Organization, highlighting a growing crisis that threatens millions across the country."*

This lead uses a striking statistic to immediately convey the seriousness of the issue, grabbing the reader's attention with a fact-based opening.

Each type serves a different purpose, depending on the story's context and the audience's needs.

